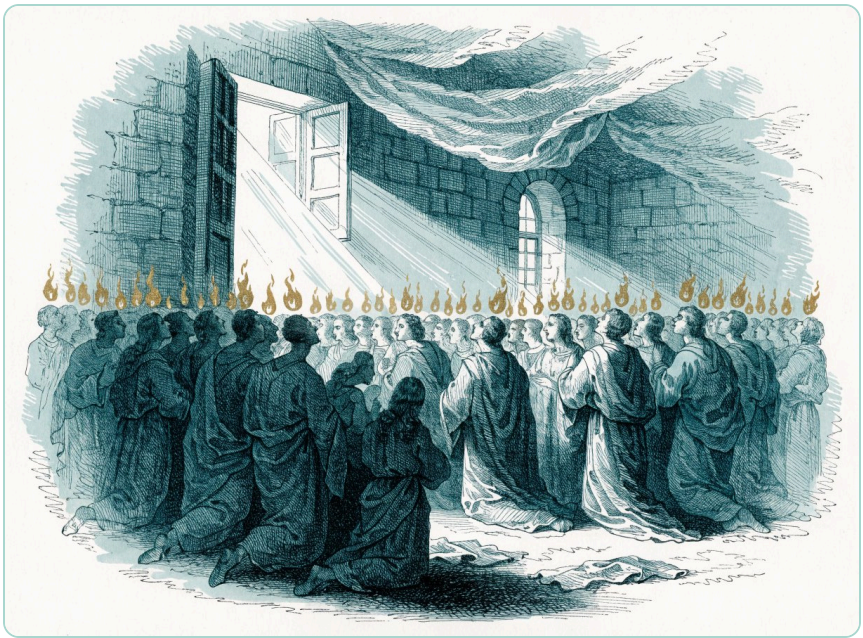
490.LIFE · THE WHOLE STORY · LESSON 23 OF 26

Acts: The Spirit and the Church

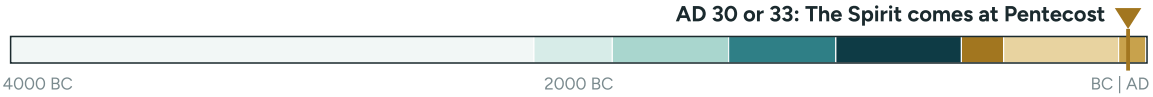
Acts 1–12



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YOU ARE HERE · LESSON 23



Introduction: What Jesus Began

The night before he died, Jesus told his disciples something that must have sounded impossible: "it is to your advantage that I go away, for if I do not go away, the Helper will not come to you" (John 16:7). How could anything be better than having Jesus physically with them?

The book of Acts answers that question. It was written by Luke, the same doctor who wrote the Gospel of Luke, and he begins it this way: "In the first book, O Theophilus, I have dealt with all that Jesus *began* to do and teach" (Acts 1:1, emphasis added). The Gospel was what Jesus began. Acts is what he continued to do, from heaven, through his Spirit and his people. In about thirty years, a frightened band of followers in one city became a movement across the Roman Empire.

This lesson opens Unit 6, "The Church and the End." It covers Acts 1–12: the coming of the Holy Spirit, the birth of the church, the first persecution, and the gospel breaking out beyond the Jewish people. On our timeline, it begins at Pentecost in AD 30 or 33, just seven weeks after the resurrection.

The Word: Spirit

> **John 14:16–17** *"And I will ask the Father, and he will give you another Helper, to be with you forever, even the Spirit of truth, whom the world cannot receive, because it neither sees him nor knows him. You know him, for he dwells with you and will be in you."*

πνεῦμα *(pneuma, "Spirit")*

wind, breath, spirit

Hebrew *ruach*		Greek *pneuma*
Gen. 1:2	=	*John 3:8*
The Spirit of God hovering over the waters at creation.		"The wind blows where it wishes." The same word means wind and Spirit.

Payoff: The Holy Spirit is not a force or an energy. He is a Person, the third Person of the Trinity, fully God with the Father and the Son (WSC 6). Jesus calls him "another Helper," another one like himself. The same Spirit who hovered over creation and gives life to every human being (Job 33:4) came at Pentecost with the sound of a rushing wind, to make God's people his home.

Part One: The Day of Pentecost

Ten days after Jesus ascended, about a hundred and twenty believers were praying together in Jerusalem. It was the Jewish harvest festival of Pentecost, and the city was full of Jewish pilgrims from all over the world. “And suddenly there came from heaven a sound like a mighty rushing wind, and it filled the entire house where they were sitting. And divided tongues as of fire appeared to them and rested on each one of them. And they were all filled with the Holy Spirit and began to speak in other tongues as the Spirit gave them utterance” (Acts 2:2–4).

A crowd gathered, amazed, because each one heard the disciples speaking in his own native language. Remember Babel (Lesson 5), where God scattered proud humanity by confusing their languages? At Pentecost God began to undo Babel. He did not make everyone speak one language again. He spoke the gospel into every language.

Peter, the same man who had denied Jesus seven weeks earlier, stood up and preached. He explained that this was what the prophet Joel had promised: “I will pour out my Spirit on all flesh” (Acts 2:17; Joel 2:28). He told them about Jesus, whom they had crucified and God had raised. “Let all the house of Israel therefore know for certain that God has made him both Lord and Christ, this Jesus whom you crucified” (2:36).

The crowd was “cut to the heart” and asked, “Brothers, what shall we do?” Peter answered: “Repent and be baptized every one of you in the name of Jesus Christ for the forgiveness of your sins, and you will receive the gift of the Holy Spirit. For the promise is for you and for your children and for all who are far off, everyone whom the Lord our God calls to himself” (2:37–39). That day about three thousand people believed and were baptized (2:41). The water did not wash away their sins by itself. Baptism was God’s visible mark and seal on those who belonged to Jesus, and Peter was careful to say the promise included their children. The church was born.

Part Two: The First Church

What did these new believers do? Luke gives us a snapshot:

> **Acts 2:42, 46–47** *“And they devoted themselves to the apostles’ teaching and the fellowship, to the breaking of bread and the prayers…. And day by day, attending the temple together and breaking bread in their homes, they received their food with glad and generous hearts, praising God and having favor with all the people. And the Lord added to their number day by day those who were being saved.”*



"They devoted themselves to the apostles' teaching and the fellowship, to the breaking of bread and the prayers" (Acts 2:42).

Four things marked them: the apostles' teaching (God's word), fellowship (shared life), the breaking of bread (including the Lord's Supper), and prayer. These are still the marks of a healthy church today. Christians call God's word, the sacraments (baptism and the Lord's Supper, the meal Jesus gave his church the night before he died), and prayer the "means of grace," the ordinary ways God gives and strengthens the new life Christ won for his people (WSC 88).

Their love was practical. "There was not a needy person among them," because people with land or houses sold them and gave the money so that "it was distributed to each as any had need" (4:34–35). No one was forced to; it was the overflow of grace. A new kind of family had been born, made up of rich and poor, young and old. The New Testament calls the church a body with many parts (1 Cor. 12:12–13), a holy temple where God lives by his Spirit (Eph. 2:21–22), and "a chosen race, a royal priesthood, a holy nation, a people for his own possession" (1 Pet. 2:9).

Part Three: Bold Under Fire

The religious leaders who had condemned Jesus soon arrested Peter and John after they healed a crippled man in Jesus' name and preached that Jesus had risen (3:1–4:3). Peter, "filled with the Holy Spirit," told the council, "there is salvation in no one else, for there is no other name under heaven given among men by which we must be saved" (4:8, 12). When they were ordered to stop speaking about Jesus, Peter and John answered, "we cannot but speak of what we have seen and heard" (4:20). Later, when all the apostles were arrested, Peter and the others said, "We must obey God rather than men" (5:29). After being beaten, they left "rejoicing that they were counted worthy to suffer dishonor for the name" (5:41).

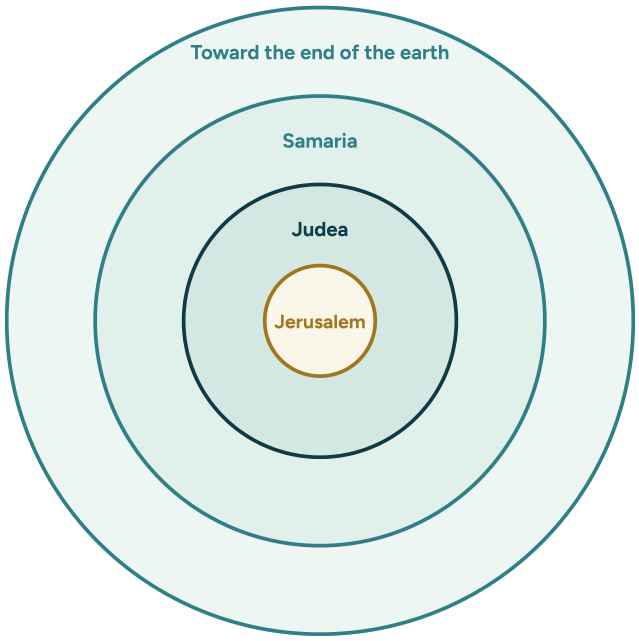
Then came the first martyr. Stephen was one of seven men chosen to care for the church's widows (6:1–6), and he preached boldly before the council. "Full of the Holy Spirit," he looked up and saw "the Son of Man standing at the right hand of God" (7:55–56). They dragged him out of the city and stoned him, and as he died he prayed, "Lord, do not hold this sin against them" (7:60), just as Jesus had prayed on the cross. Watching, holding the coats of the men throwing the stones, was a young man named Saul (7:58).

A wave of persecution followed, and the believers scattered throughout Judea and Samaria, though the apostles stayed in Jerusalem (8:1). But look what happened: "Now those who were scattered went about preaching the word" (8:4). The persecution meant to stop the church spread it. And Saul, the persecutor, was stopped in his tracks on the road to Damascus by a light from heaven and a voice: "Saul, Saul, why are you persecuting me?… I am Jesus, whom you are persecuting" (9:4–5). The church's fiercest enemy would become its greatest missionary. That is Lesson 24.

Part Four: To the Ends of the Earth

Jesus had given the plan in Acts 1:8: Jerusalem, then Judea and Samaria, then the end of the earth. Acts follows that plan step by step, and Lesson 24 carries it all the way to Rome.

Witnesses: The Gospel Widens (Acts 1:8)



Jerusalem — *Acts 1–7*
Pentecost, 3,000 believe; the first church

Judea — *Acts 8:1–4*
Believers scattered by persecution preach the word

Samaria — *Acts 8:5–25*
Philip preaches; Samaritans believe

Toward the end of the earth — *Acts 8–11; 28*
An Ethiopian official, a Roman officer, Antioch; then Paul to Rome

"But the word of God increased and multiplied" (Acts 12:24).

Philip, another of the seven chosen with Stephen (not the apostle Philip), preached in Samaria, among the people the Jews despised, and many believed. Then the Spirit sent him to a desert road, where an Ethiopian official was riding in his chariot reading Isaiah 53: "Like a sheep he was led to the slaughter"

(8:32). “Do you understand what you are reading?” Philip asked. “How can I, unless someone guides me?” And “beginning with this Scripture he told him the good news about Jesus” (8:30–31, 35). The man believed and was baptized, and he went on his way rejoicing, carrying the gospel toward Africa.

Then came the hardest barrier of all. Peter, a devout Jew, would never have entered the home of a Gentile, someone who was not a Jew (10:28). God gave him a vision of unclean animals and a voice: “What God has made clean, do not call common” (10:15). While Peter was still puzzling over it, messengers arrived from Cornelius, a Roman army officer who feared God. Peter went to his house and said, “Truly I understand that God shows no partiality” (10:34). While Peter was still preaching about Jesus, “the Holy Spirit fell on all who heard the word,” and Peter had them baptized (10:44, 48). When the church in Jerusalem heard Peter’s report, they fell silent and then praised God: “Then to the Gentiles also God has granted repentance that leads to life” (11:18).



“Truly I understand that God shows no partiality” (Acts 10:34).

In Antioch, a great city to the north, Jews and Gentiles worshiped together, and “in Antioch the disciples were first called Christians” (11:26). The promise to Abraham, “in you all the families of the earth shall be blessed” (Gen. 12:3; Lesson 6), was coming true. King Herod killed the apostle James and threw Peter in prison, but an angel led Peter out (12:1–11). Kings and councils tried to stop it, but Luke closes this part of the story simply: “But the word of God increased and multiplied” (12:24).

What the Holy Spirit Does

1	**Gives new birth** Opens blind eyes and makes dead hearts alive	*John 3:5–8; Titus 3:5*
2	**Unites us to Christ** Joins believers to Jesus and to one body	*1 Cor. 12:13; Rom. 8:9*
3	**Assures us** Bears witness that we are children of God	*Rom. 8:15–16*
4	**Seals us** The guarantee of our inheritance	*Eph. 1:13–14*
5	**Makes us holy** Grows the fruit of love, joy, peace, and more	*Gal. 5:22–23*
6	**Makes us bold** Gives power to witness to Christ	*Acts 1:8; 4:31*

"He will glorify me, for he will take what is mine and declare it to you" (John 16:14).

THREAD WATCH

GOD WITH HIS PEOPLE Fire came down on Mount Sinai (Ex. 19:18), on the tabernacle (Lev. 9:23–24), and on Solomon's temple (2 Chron. 7:1) to show that God had come to dwell. At Pentecost, tongues of fire rested on each believer. The temple of God is now his people: "In him you also are being built together into a dwelling place for God by the Spirit" (Eph. 2:22).

THE LAMB The Ethiopian was reading Isaiah 53, "Like a sheep he was led to the slaughter," and Philip told him who the Lamb was. The message of the church from the first day was the Lamb who was slain and raised: "there is no other name under heaven given among men by which we must be saved" (Acts 4:12).

The Turn: The Promise Is for You

On the day of Pentecost, the crowd asked the most important question anyone can ask: "Brothers, what shall we do?" Peter's answer still stands: turn from your sin to Jesus, receive his forgiveness and the gift of the Holy Spirit, and be baptized as the sign that you belong to him. "For the promise is for you and for your children and for all who are far off, everyone whom the Lord our God calls to himself" (Acts 2:39). "All who are far off" meant the nations, people with no connection to Israel at all. If you feel far off, that line is for you, and God is calling you through these very words.

And notice that the first Christians did not follow Jesus alone. They joined his people. They devoted themselves to God's word, to each other, to the Lord's Supper, and to prayer. The Christian life is meant to be lived in a church, where the Spirit uses ordinary means to grow ordinary people. "Not neglecting to meet together… but encouraging one another" (Heb. 10:25).

The same Spirit who came at Pentecost gives new life today. God "saved us, not because of works done by us in righteousness, but according to his own mercy, by the washing of regeneration and renewal of the Holy Spirit" (Titus 3:5). That washing is the Spirit's own work inside us, giving us a new heart. Baptism is the outward sign of it. If you have never turned to Christ, ask God for his Spirit, turn from your sin, and trust Jesus as Lord and Christ. And if you have, find your place among God's people, and be his witness where you are.

Living It: Six Practices for This Week

1. **Read Acts.** Read Acts 1–4 and 9–10 this week. Watch for every time the Holy Spirit is mentioned.
2. **Devote yourself.** Look at the four marks in Acts 2:42. Which one is weakest in your life? Take one step to strengthen it.
3. **Join a church.** If you are not part of a local church, visit one this Sunday that preaches the Bible, and ask about membership.
4. **Give practically.** The first believers met each other's needs. Meet one real need in your church or neighborhood this week.
5. **Speak up.** Peter and John said, "we cannot but speak." Tell one person what Jesus means to you.
6. **Memorize Acts 1:8.** "But you will receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you, and you will be my witnesses in Jerusalem and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the end of the earth."

Before Lesson 24: *Read Acts 9:1–31, 13–14, and 16, and Romans 1:16–17 and 5:1–11. Lesson 24 follows Paul, the persecutor turned apostle, and the letters he wrote.*

For Discussion

1. Jesus said it was to their advantage that he go away. Why would having the Spirit be better than having Jesus physically present?
2. At Pentecost, people heard the gospel in their own languages. How does that reverse Babel?
3. The crowd asked, "What shall we do?" What did Peter tell them, and what does that mean for you?
4. Acts 2:42 lists four things the first Christians devoted themselves to. Which is strongest in your life? Which is weakest?
5. Persecution scattered the believers, and they preached wherever they went. Have you seen hardship spread the gospel?
6. Peter had to learn that "God shows no partiality." What barriers between people does the gospel break down today?
7. Why does the Christian life need to be lived in a church, and not just privately?

Sources & For Further Study

- On the person and work of the Holy Spirit: Sinclair B. Ferguson, *The Holy Spirit*; Westminster Shorter Catechism 6, 29–30, 88.
- On Acts: Dennis E. Johnson, *The Message of Acts in the History of Redemption*; John Stott, *The Message of Acts*.
- For further reading: Mark Dever, *What Is a Healthy Church?*; Michael Green, *Evangelism in the Early Church*.



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